ART

EARTH *and* Fire

The second edition of the Indian Ceramics Triennale, themed **'Common Ground'**, will showcase the work of over 60 Indian and international artists



Around 2016, six friends—Anjani Khanna, Madhvi Subrahmanian, Neha Kudchadkar, Reyaz Badaruddin, Sharbani Das Gupta and Vineet Kacker—decided that India needed an event that showcased the depth of ceramic art practice in the country, something they felt the broader art world had not recognised.

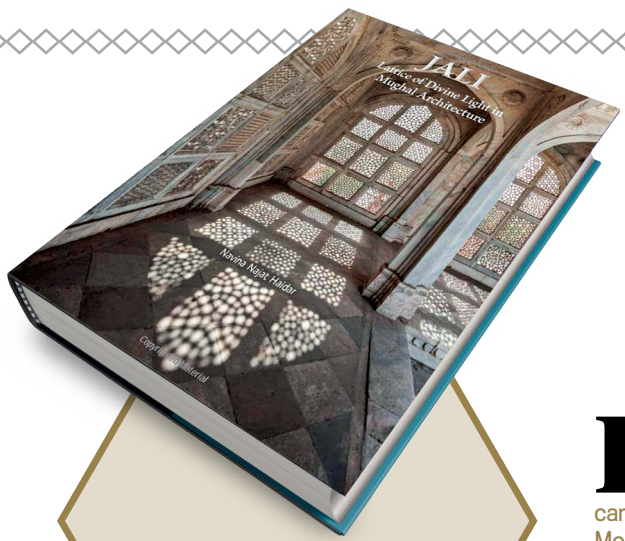
Ceramics, as Subrahmanian puts it, "is one of the oldest [arts] and the youngest". She explains that archaeology has shown us ceramics from thousands of years ago, but "it's the youngest because it's not been considered contemporary art. There's been this craft-art divide which is a western concept [India has imported]. Paintings are sacred and anything to do with clay is only *mitti ka kaam* [mud work]."

The friends, all mid-career artists, saw a lacuna. So, in 2017, they set up the Contemporary Clay Foundation, and under it, in 2018, the first edition of the Indian Ceramics Triennale (ICT) in Jaipur. Called 'Breaking Ground', it was well received. As important, Kudchadkar says, is the indirect effect: "People are starting to take the medium seriously." Das Gupta adds, "Many more people are actively pursuing ceramics, there are shows happening all over the country, which was not the case when we started."

The second ICT should have been in 2021, but like most of the world's plans, Covid-19 put paid to that. But it opens, now, in Delhi, the first event in the new Arthshila branch in Okhla.

Unusually for such events, the curators don't ask for final works: they put out a call for projects, and selected artists are then asked to execute them. For this edition—called 'Common Ground'—they got over 370 applications from 54 countries, from which they selected 34 projects by over 60 artists (many are collaborative works). Aside from the exhibits, there are also interactive sessions, walkthroughs, workshops, films, lectures, a symposium and exhibitions at other venues.

Also unusual is that ICT's curators, besides being practising artists, double up as its fundraisers, event managers, administrators and,



JALI: Lattice of Divine Light in Mughal Architecture
by Navina Najat Haidar
MAPIN
₹2,950; 272 pages

BOOKS

Framing the Divine

Navina Najat Haidar's *Jali* is a well-researched book that explores the significance of the lattice in Mughal architecture

It is only appropriate that the first double spread in this sumptuous exploration of the *jali* is the carved arch from the Sidi Sayyid Mosque in Ahmedabad. This swirling emanation, crafted stone brought to vegetal life as a *kalpavriksha* or a Blessed Tree in Paradise is metonymic of the syncretism at the confluence of Islamic and Indic art practices.

The *jali* is etymologically Sanskrit, meaning net or web. Architecturally, a *jali* is a perforated wall, or a latticed opening. An articulated fenestration, it modulates light into interior spaces, filters and softens it in a manner only possible (and necessary) in harsh West or South Asian environments.

The evolution of this architectural element through its aesthetic, utilitarian and metaphysical avatars is presented vividly by Navina Najat